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EDUCATION

Indian Professor Expelled from ICME'15 for Caste-Critical Comments During Vedic Math Session

On 12th July 2024, Professor Jayasree Subramanian was physically escorted from ICME-15 in Sydney and stripped of her registration after raising questions about caste and Brahminical supremacy during a session on Vedic mathematics — a report on the incident, the testimony that circulated in its wake, and what it says about academic gatekeeping.

BY MOULI SHARMA

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“Professor Subramanian mentioned that some of the books and articles that were cited about Vedic mathematics in the introduction had been discredited. Professor Subramanian even mentioned that one the cited authors had disavowed the idea that a Vedic mathematics even exists. I appreciated this insight, as it revealed to me the ways propaganda and revisionist history are not found only in the mathematics context of the USA, but are universal. I also appreciated learning about the controversy over the ways that mathematics in India is situated and talked about. And I especially appreciated the connection back to the unjust caste system, particularly because it reinforced the little that I knew about the ways that Brahmin ideology often positions itself as the one and only true caste, and thereby the official holders of mathematics knowledge.” – Theodore Chao, Professor of Mathematics, Ohio State University.

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“To me, it feels that Professor Subramanian is being unjustly targeted because she dared to call out injustice and the relationship of the Indian caste system to the content of this session. I also note that Professor Subramanian is an Indian woman who speaks with a strong and authoritative voice. Positioning her as a threat seems to invoke the same forms of misogyny and racism that continually oppress women of color globally.” – Theodore Chao, Professor of Mathematics,

Professor Jayasree Subramanian was reportedly physically escorted away from the convention center by security guards for the points she made during the session, as well as had her badge & registration revoked without due procedure, apparently because “other participants” found her points “threatening.”

25th July 2024: On the 12th of July, 2024, two days before the completion of the 15th International Congress on Mathematical Education^[1] in Sydney, math & math education professor at the Department of Mathematics, SRM University (AP) Dr. Jayasree Subramanian was expelled from the conference due to, ironically, speaking out at a session based on Indian approaches to mathematical education, specifically the ‘Vedic Approach’.



SOURCE: SRM UNIVERSITY (AP)

Subramanian raised a few points when the floor was opened for discussion, including that of the Vedic system’s relationship with caste and Brahminical supremacy. “First, Professor Subramanian raised the point that the presenter was presenting Indian mathematics as one of only two mathematics cultures, European mathematics being the other. She questioned why Professor Arora did not acknowledge the other forms of mathematics such as Chinese or Egyptian or Inca mathematics and mentioned that not acknowledging other mathematical cultures is problematic.

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Second, Professor Subramanian brought up that Professor Arora did not mention that the idea of Vedic mathematics actually centers the idea of Brahmin supremacy within the unjust caste system that still pervades India today. Personally, I did not know much about this background. So, I appreciated that Professor Subramanian brought this up. For a conference like ICME, I feel we should be talking heavily about humanity and injustice, particularly within mathematics education. So this information helped me situate and understand culturally the role and space of what is labeled as Vedic Mathematics.

Third, Professor Subramanian mentioned that some of the books and articles that were cited about Vedic mathematics in the introduction had been discredited. Professor Subramanian even mentioned that one of the cited authors had disavowed the idea that a 'Vedic' mathematics even exists. I appreciated this insight, as it revealed to me the ways propaganda and revisionist history are not found only in the mathematics context of the USA but are universal. I also appreciated learning about the controversy over the ways that mathematics in India is situated and talked about. And I especially appreciated the connection back to the unjust caste system, particularly because it reinforced the little that I knew about the ways that Brahmin ideology often positions itself as the one and only true caste, and thereby the official holders of mathematics knowledge," wrote Chao.

For this, she was met with heckling by other participants who claimed that 'critical conversation' was not appropriate for the session. After the session, Subramanian was expelled from the ICME - a conference she has been part of for its past three iterations, having chaired a Study Group herself in the previous one. According to a report by The Federal, which has since been deleted, 'security guards escorted Prof. Subramanian away from the International Convention & Exhibition Centre (ICC), and her badge and registration were revoked.' Those who spoke against her faced no action.

According to the organisers, these drastic steps were taken because 'some participants' found Subramanian's points 'threatening.' While the existence, identity, or logic of these participants remains debatable, as none of them have yet come forward to the media, many others have come forward in defense of the Indian professor.

"In no way did I find anything that Professor Subramanian said to be antagonistic or confrontational. Nor did I feel that there was any risk of violence or threats in the room. In fact, I felt that the conversations that came about because of Jayasree's comments led to a better conversation for everybody in the room because it helped connect the content to mathematics education," Theodore Chao, a professor at Ohio State who was seated a row ahead of Subramanian & witnessed the whole session, went on to say.

Chao has submitted a written testimony^[2] to the ICME describing the incident in detail and accusing the organisation of latent white supremacy, misogyny, and elitism. Chao's testimony, from which the above quote is taken & which has now been widely circulated in academic circles along with a petition seeking a public apology from the ICME on behalf of Subramanian, provides an insider's perspective into what happened in the ICC on the 12th of July, 2024, and paints a very different picture of the incident than the nominal explanation given by the event's organisers. Far from feeling threatened by Jayasree, the testimony & petition reveal it was rather the ICME's behavior and actions that participants found threatening, leaving academics like Chao to wonder if the conference "was a safe space for women of color."

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According to *The Federal's* report, the day after her expulsion, Subramanian was invited back to participate in a Plenary Panel for the event on a subject she holds expertise in: "*Mathematics Education Effectively Responds to Humanity's Problems.*" However, the badge she was issued was a temporary one, and after the completion of the panel, she was escorted out of the ICC by security yet again.

It is also noteworthy that neither the initial expulsion nor this temporary readmission was carried out via due procedure, but seemingly at whim & convenience, further implicating the ICME of unjust targeting & willful humiliation of Subramanian as punishment for being an "Indian woman who speaks with a strong authoritative voice" & for using that voice to call out caste injustice.

It seems that even in 2024, at the international conference of an organisation that posits itself as the flagbearer of progress & inclusivity in mathematical education, caste & color reign supreme. And it seems, that even in Sydney, surnames matter.

| See Also:

1. Stay up to date - ICME-15 (icme15.org)^[1]
2. “Professor Subramanian is Being Targeted Because She Dared to Call Out the Relationship of the Indian Caste System with Vedic Mathematics” – The Voice Express (Archived)^[2]
3. The Federal, 16th July 2024: “Indian Professor Expelled from ICME15 After Raising Questions on Vedic Mathematics” - Retrieved, 25th July 2024 by TVE^[3]

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



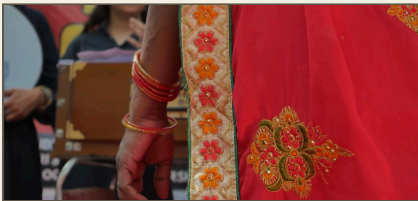
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Mouli Sharma is a journalist, freelance illustrator, and writer from New Delhi, India. She is a published photojournalist & illustrator, having been featured in The Hindu College Gazette, & the quarterly Pink Disco. Mouli took over as the Editor of The Voice Express (<https://thevoiceexpress.github.io/e-mag/>) back in September 2023.

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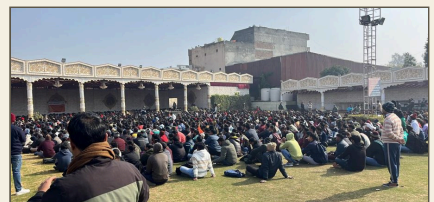
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[1] 15th International Congress on Mathematical Education

[2] written testimony

[3] The Federal, 16th July 2024: "Indian Professor Expelled from ICME15 After Raising Questions on Vedic Mathematics" - Retrieved, 25th July 2024 by TVE